

Désirée's Baby

Kate Chopin · 1893

First published: Vogue, Jan 1893

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Bayou_Folk/Désirée's_Baby (revision 11819727), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Désirée's Baby suggest about race and identity?
- What does Désirée's Baby suggest about pride and cruelty?
- What does Désirée's Baby suggest about slavery?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Désirée's Baby	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*race and identity* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Désirée's Baby

Focus: racial pride destroying love

Content note (slavery and racism, racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central, implied suicide, suicide): Sensitive content: Slavery and racism; racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central; implied suicide. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes slavery and racism; racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central; implied suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this story is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Désirée, a foundling raised by the Valmondés, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny. When their baby begins to show African ancestry, Armand turns cold and sends her away; she walks with the baby into the bayou and does not return. Burning her things, Armand finds a letter from his own mother, revealing that she belonged to 'the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.'

Background: Published in Vogue in 1893 and set in antebellum Louisiana, where Creole society enforced rigid racial classification.

Significance: Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *Settle in and write for five minutes: How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes slavery and racism; racial slurs absent but racial hierarchy central; implied suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.*

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are muslins, avalanche, thanking, narrowly, prevailing. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch." In this sentence it means: plain-woven cotton fabric. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Désirée's Baby would have known. Published in Vogue in 1893 and set in antebellum Louisiana, where Creole society enforced rigid racial classification. Why does this story matter? Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The little one awoke in his arms and began to cry for "Dada." That was as much as she could do or say." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to racial pride destroying love? I circle "prevailing", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *The little one awoke in his arms and began to cry for "Dada." That was as much as she could do or say. Some people thought she might have strayed there of her own accord, for she was of the toddling age. The prevailing belief was that she had been purposely left by a party of Texans, whose canvas-covered wagon, late in the day, had crossed the ferry that Coton Mais kept, just below the plantation. In time Madame Valmondé abandoned every speculation but the one that Désirée had been sent to her by a beneficent Providence to be the child of her affection, seeing that she was without child of the flesh. For the girl grew to be beautiful and gentle, affectionate and sincere,--the idol of Valmondé.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Symbolism, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Désirée's Baby develops the idea of racial pride destroying love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to race and identity? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about racial pride destroying love, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes racial pride destroying love. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
muslins (noun)	plain-woven cotton fabric	*The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
avalanche (noun)	a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain	*The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
thanking (verb)	expressing gratitude to	*She was thanking God for the blessing of her husband's love:--*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*She scanned the baby narrowly, then looked as searchingly at Zandrine, whose face was turned to gaze across the fields.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
prevailing (verb)	be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance	*The prevailing belief was that she had been purposely left by a party of Texans, whose canvas-covered wagon, late in the day, had crossed the ferry that Coton Mais kept, just below the plantation.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
obstacles (noun)		*The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a*	

	something immaterial that stands in the way and must be circumvented or surmounted	*prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
unjustly (adverb)	in an unjust manner	*He thought Almighty God had dealt cruelly and unjustly with him; and felt, somehow, that he was paying Him back in kind when he stabbed thus into his wife's soul.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
recovering (verb)	regaining self-control	*The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with race and identity?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How did Désirée come to the Valmondés? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: She was found as a baby by a stone pillar
2. What is L'Abri like? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A gloomy, sad-looking plantation
3. What change does Désirée notice in the baby? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Signs of African ancestry
4. What does Armand burn? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Désirée's belongings in a bonfire
5. What does the final letter reveal? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Armand's mother was of African descent
6. Retell the three most important events of “Désirée's Baby” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Désirée, a foundling raised by the Valmondés, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny. When their baby begins to show African ancestry, Armand turns cold and sends her away; she walks with the baby into the bayou and does not return. Burning her things, Armand finds a letter from his own mother, revealing that she belonged to 'the race that is cursed with the brand of slavery.'

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Désirée's Baby”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Désirée's Baby” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.” What does “muslins” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: muslins: plain-woven cotton fabric.
10. Reread: “The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.” What does “avalanche” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: avalanche: a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Désirée's Baby” suggest about racial pride destroying love? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about racial pride destroying love? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “The little one awoke in his arms and began to cry for "Dada." That was as much as she could do or say.”, why might Chopin have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Désirée's Baby”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Désirée, a foundling raised by the Valmondés, marries the proud planter Armand Aubigny. When their baby begins to show African ancestry, Armand turns cold and sends her away; she walks with the baby into the bayou and does not return. Burning her things, Armand finds a letter from his own mother,…
6. As the opening story, what does “Désirée's Baby” set up that the rest of Désirée's Baby will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can a single fact change how people treat someone they love?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with race and identity? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in Vogue in 1893 and set in antebellum Louisiana, where Creole society enforced rigid racial classification. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "Its final reversal exposes the arbitrariness of racial categories." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "Désirée's Baby" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about racial pride destroying love? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "Désirée's Baby": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to pride and cruelty: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chopin need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "Désirée's Baby" treats racial pride destroying love with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Désirée's Baby see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve race and identity? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about racial pride destroying love? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Kate Chopin about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. How did Désirée come to the Valmondés?
   A. She was found as a baby by a stone pillar
   B. She was born there
   C. She was adopted from a convent
   D. She was a cousin
2. What is L'Abri like?
   A. A convent
   B. A riverboat
   C. A gloomy, sad-looking plantation
   D. A cheerful town house
3. What change does Désirée notice in the baby?
   A. An illness
   B. Signs of African ancestry
   C. Blindness
   D. A birthmark
4. What does Armand burn?
   A. Désirée's belongings in a bonfire
   B. The letters of his father
   C. His house
   D. The cradle only
5. What does the final letter reveal?
   A. Désirée was rich
   B. His father was alive
   C. Armand's mother was of African descent
   D. The baby was not his
6. In the line “The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.”, what does “muslins” most nearly mean?
   A. closely; carefully
   B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   C. expressing gratitude to
   D. plain-woven cotton fabric
7. In the line “The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?
   A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   B. expressing gratitude to

C. plain-woven cotton fabric

D. closely; carefully

Answer key: 1. A (She was found as a baby by a stone pillar); 2. C (A gloomy, sad-looking plantation); 3. B (Signs of African ancestry); 4. A (Désirée's belongings in a bonfire); 5. C (Armand's mother was of African descent); 6. D (plain-woven cotton fabric); 7. A (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Désirée's Baby,” how does Chopin show racial pride destroying love? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In Désirée's Baby, how does Chopin develop the idea of racial pride destroying love? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Désirée's Baby develops the idea of racial pride destroying love. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Désirée's Baby (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of racial pride destroying love. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Désirée's Baby suggests about racial pride destroying love. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Kate Chopin uses irony in Désirée's Baby to complicate the reader's understanding of racial pride destroying love. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Désirée's Baby within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of racial pride destroying love responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Désirée's Baby alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of racial pride destroying love follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Désirée's Baby and its treatment of racial pride destroying love. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Désirée's Baby as evidence for a larger claim about racial pride destroying love in Désirée's Baby. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Désirée's Baby as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of racial pride destroying love. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Désirée's Baby.

SAT-style questions

1. *She was thanking God for the blessing of her husband's love:--*

   As used in the text, what does the word “thanking” most nearly mean?

   A. something immaterial that stands in the way and must be circumvented or surmounted

   B. expressing gratitude to

   C. regaining self-control

   D. in an unjust manner

2. *The little one awoke in his arms and began to cry for "Dada." That was as much as she could do or say. Some people thought she might have strayed there of her own accord, for she was of the toddling age. The prevailing belief was that she had been purposely left by a party of Texans, whose canvas-covered wagon, late in the day, had crossed the ferry that Coton Mais kept, just below the plantation. In time Madame Valmondé abandoned every speculation but the one that Désirée had been sent to her by a beneficent Providence to be the child of her affection, seeing that she was without child of the flesh. For the girl grew to be beautiful and gentle, affectionate and sincere,--the idol of Valmondé.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Désirée's Baby”?

   A. Racial pride destroying love

   B. The closing of the frontier

   C. Superstition used against a credulous man

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. B (expressing gratitude to); 2. A (Racial pride destroying love)

Whole-book test

Désirée's Baby: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How did Désirée come to the Valmondés?
   A. She was found as a baby by a stone pillar
   B. She was born there
   C. She was adopted from a convent
   D. She was a cousin
2. What is L'Abri like?
   A. A convent
   B. A riverboat
   C. A gloomy, sad-looking plantation
   D. A cheerful town house
3. What change does Désirée notice in the baby?
   A. An illness
   B. Signs of African ancestry
   C. Blindness
   D. A birthmark
4. What does Armand burn?
   A. Désirée's belongings in a bonfire
   B. The letters of his father
   C. His house
   D. The cradle only
5. What does the final letter reveal?
   A. Désirée was rich
   B. His father was alive
   C. Armand's mother was of African descent
   D. The baby was not his
6. In the line “The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.”, what does “muslins” most nearly mean?
   A. closely; carefully
   B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   C. expressing gratitude to
   D. plain-woven cotton fabric

7. In the line “The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything that drives headlong over all obstacles.”, what does “avalanche” most nearly mean?
   A. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   B. expressing gratitude to
   C. plain-woven cotton fabric
   D. closely; carefully
8. As used in the story (“The young mother was recovering slowly, and lay full length, in her soft white muslins and laces, upon a couch.”), what does “muslins” mean?
   A. plain-woven cotton fabric
   B. be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance
   C. regaining self-control
   D. closely; carefully
9. As used in the story (“The passion that awoke in him that day, when he saw her at the gate, swept along like an avalanche, or like a prairie fire, or like anything”), what does “avalanche” mean?
   A. something immaterial that stands in the way and must be circumvented or surmounted
   B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
   C. plain-woven cotton fabric
   D. be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance
10. As used in the story (“She was thanking God for the blessing of her husband's love:--”), what does “thanking” mean?
    A. in an unjust manner
    B. a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain
    C. expressing gratitude to
    D. something immaterial that stands in the way and must be circumvented or surmounted
11. As used in the story (“She scanned the baby narrowly, then looked as searchingly at Zandrine, whose face was turned to gaze across the fields.”), what does “narrowly” mean?
    A. regaining self-control
    B. expressing gratitude to
    C. in an unjust manner
    D. closely; carefully
12. As used in the story (“The prevailing belief was that she had been purposely left by a party of Texans, whose canvas-covered wagon, late in the day, had crossed th”), what does “prevailing” mean?
    A. be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance
    B. plain-woven cotton fabric
    C. closely; carefully
    D. regaining self-control

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how race and identity develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how pride and cruelty develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how slavery develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (race and identity, pride and cruelty, slavery) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. A (She was found as a baby by a stone pillar); 2. C (A gloomy, sad-looking plantation); 3. B (Signs of African ancestry); 4. A (Désirée's belongings in a bonfire); 5. C (Armand's mother was of African descent); 6. D (plain-woven cotton fabric); 7. A (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain); 8. A (plain-woven cotton fabric); 9. B (a slide of large masses of snow and ice and mud down a mountain); 10. C (expressing gratitude to); 11. D (closely; carefully); 12. A (be larger in number, quantity, power, status or importance)

Essay assignments

Essay: Race and identity

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Désirée's Baby teaches about race and identity. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops race and identity in Désirée's Baby. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops race and identity across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Désirée's Baby (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of race and identity. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of race and identity in Désirée's Baby. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in Désirée's Baby (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of race and identity, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Désirée's Baby's treatment of race and identity in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on race and identity in Désirée's Baby that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on race and identity in Désirée's Baby. Name your critical method,

apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about race and identity in Désirée's Baby, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on race and identity in Désirée's Baby, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Pride and cruelty

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Désirée's Baby teaches about pride and cruelty. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops pride and cruelty across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Désirée's Baby (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of pride and cruelty. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in Désirée's Baby (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of pride and cruelty, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Désirée's Baby's treatment of pride and cruelty in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on pride and cruelty in Désirée's Baby, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Slavery

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Désirée's Baby teaches about slavery. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Kate Chopin develops slavery in Désirée's Baby. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Kate Chopin develops slavery across Désirée's Baby. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Désirée's Baby (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of slavery. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of slavery in Désirée's Baby. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Kate Chopin's choices in Désirée's Baby (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of slavery, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Désirée's Baby's treatment of slavery in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on slavery in Désirée's Baby that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on slavery in Désirée's Baby. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about slavery in Désirée's Baby, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on slavery in Désirée's Baby, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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